HILCHOT SHABBAT

# Soap, Snow & Sponges: Can You Use Soap on Shabbat?

**Given Thursday 4 June 2026** · Hilchot Shabbat 320 Seifim 10-18 — מלאכת דש

**Sefer:** Shulchan Aruch · Orach Chaim **Siman:** 320 (ש"כ) **Topic:** מלאכת דש — Threshing & Squeezing (Continued) **Tonight's Seifim:** 10 (breaking ice) · 11 (washing hands with snow) · 12 (salt & soap) · 13 (walking on snow) · 14 (urinating in snow) · 15 (towel over water) · 16 (wedging cotton in a jug) · 17 (sponges) · Beginning 18 (the flax stopper & psik reisha d'lo nicha lei) **Plus:** Freezing water on Shabbat · The full discussion of soap · Introduction to Melaben's relationship with Dash

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## Recap — The Structure of Siman 320

| Part | Seifim | Content |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | א–ח | Mefarek/Sechita: three categories of fruit, lemons, pickles, squeezing onto solids |
| 2 | ט–יד | Crushing ice and snow — the rabbinic extensions |
| 3 | טו–יח | Sechita of Melaben vs. Sechita of Dash — towels, sponges, stoppers |
| (End) | יט–כ | Melechet Tzovei'a (dyeing) — to be learned separately |

### Recap of Part 2 So Far (Last Week)

**The Gemara:** אין מרסקין לא את השלג ולא את הברד, אבל נותן הוא לתוך הכוס ואינו חושש — one may not crush snow or hail on Shabbat, but may put it into a cup.

**Three reasons in the Rishonim:**

| Rishon | Reason | Nature of Problem |
|---|---|---|
| **Rambam** | דומה לדש — similar to Dash | The **action** of producing liquid from solid |
| **Rashi** | מכה בפטיש — creating something new | The **action** |
| **Ba'al HaTerumah** (Rabbeinu Baruch of Mainz) | **Nolad** — a new entity exists that didn't exist when Shabbat began | The **result** |

**The Shulchan Aruch** clearly holds like Rambam (he placed these halachot in the Dash chapter) — and we'll see tonight he also incorporates Rashi's reasoning.

**Practical results established last week:**

- **Leaving ice to melt on its own**: Sefardim permitted (Rashi/Rambam — no action); Ashkenazim should not in the first instance (Ba'al HaTerumah/Rema — the result is the problem)
- **Putting ice cubes into a drink**: Permitted by all (the transformation is never discernible — immediately mixed in)
- **Crushing the ice once it's in the drink**: Ba'al HaTerumah permits (result is absorbed); Rashi/Rambam — machloket; **Shulchan Aruch rules strictly** → Sefardim should not crush ice cubes in their Coke; Ashkenazim have room to be lenient

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## Seif 10 — Breaking Ice to Reach the Water

**מותר לשבר הקרח כדי ליטול מים מתחתיו** *.It is permitted to break ice in order to take the water beneath it*

### The Case

A frozen pool/mikveh/body of water on a cold morning — you may break the ice to reach the water underneath (e.g., for tevillah).

The Gemara in Berachot says **Benayahu ben Yehoyada** broke the ice to immerse in a mikveh — and there are many Chassidic stories of the same.

### The Question

We just learned you may NOT crush ice! Why is breaking ice permitted?

### The Answer — Intention

Look back at Seif 9: the prohibition is crushing **כדי שיזובו מימיו** — *in order that its water should flow*. The entire rabbinic prohibition (under all three reasons) is when your purpose is to CREATE liquid.

Here, you're breaking the ice **to access the water beneath** — not to convert the ice into water. Some liquid will incidentally result, but that's not your intention. **Permitted.**

### The Magen Avraham's Concern (Rejected)

The Magen Avraham suggested that breaking ice attached to the ground (a river) might be a problem of **stira** (destruction). **All the Poskim disagreed** — water has no binyan u'stira. **Chacham Ovadia rules outright: permitted.**

### Important Application for Ashkenazim

Based on this seif, the Ashkenazi Poskim qualify their stringency about leaving ice out to melt:

- **Problem**: Leaving ice out for an extended period **with the intention** that it melt into liquid
- **NOT a problem**: Taking ice cubes out of the freezer before serving so they soften slightly and can be extracted — some melting happens *mimela* (automatically), but you're not doing it **כדי שיזובו מימיו**

The Ashkenazi stringency only applies to intentional transformation. Incidental melting in the normal course of use is permitted for everyone.

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## Seif 11 — Washing Hands with Snow/Ice Water in Winter

**צריך ליזהר בחורף שלא יטול ידיו במים שיש בהם שלג או ברד, ואם יטול — יזהר שלא ידחקם בין ידיו שלא יהיה מרסק**

*In winter, one should be careful not to wash one's hands with water containing snow or ice. If one does wash — be careful not to press them between the hands, so as not to crush.*

### The Halacha

- Better not to wash hands with water containing snow/ice
- If you do — don't rub/press your hands together, because you'd be **crushing the ice into liquid** (and there you WANT the extra liquid to wash with)

### Critical Inference

Notice: the ice here is already mixed **with liquid water** — and still the Shulchan Aruch says don't crush it. **This proves the Shulchan Aruch holds you cannot crush solids even when they're sitting in liquid.**

This confirms what we said on Seif 9: **Sefardim should not crush ice cubes in their drink on Shabbat.**

*(Side note from Rabbi Kada: whether netilat yadayim itself works with snow is a separate question — likely problematic since it's not "mayim" — to be checked separately.)*

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## Side Topic — Freezing Water on Shabbat

**The Question:** It's a hot summer Shabbat afternoon, the ice cubes have run out. May I put water in the freezer for tonight?

*(If it's for after Shabbat → forbidden as hachana. The question is for use later the same Shabbat.)*

### The Analysis

| Opinion | Ruling | Why |
|---|---|---|
| **Rambam / Rashi (Sefardim)** | **Permitted — no issue at all** | The entire prohibition is an *action* of crushing (similar to Dash / Makeh B'Patish). Putting liquid in a freezer involves no action of crushing — it freezes on its own |
| **Ba'al HaTerumah (Ashkenazi concern)** | Question arises | If the problem is *creating something new* even passively — isn't freezing also transforming liquid → solid? |

### The Ashkenazi Resolution — Majority Lenient

A minority of Ashkenazi poskim forbid. But **the majority are lenient** — including the **Shevet HaLevi (Rav Wosner)** and **Orchot Shabbat**. Two reasons given:

1. **The Ba'al HaTerumah's chiddush was specifically solid → liquid** — creating *water*, which is more useful than the solid. Going the other way (liquid → solid) was never part of the prohibition.
2. **The prohibition only covers things subject to crushing (risuk)** — a liquid cannot be "crushed" into a solid, so the gezeira never applied.

### Bottom Line

**Everyone may freeze water into ice cubes on Shabbat** (for use that same Shabbat).

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## Seif 12 — Salt (and the Gateway to Soap)

**יש ליזהר שלא ישפשף ידיו במלח** *.One should be careful not to rub one's hands with salt*

### The Halacha

Don't rub salt between your hands — you'd be **dissolving/transforming the solid salt particles into liquid**, just like crushing ice into water.

### Working It Through the Three Reasons

| Opinion | Does the salt prohibition make sense? |
|---|---|
| **Rashi (Makeh B'Patish — creating something new)** | ✓ Yes — transforming salt to liquid creates something new |
| **Ba'al HaTerumah (Nolad — the result)** | ✓ Yes — a new liquid now exists |
| **Rambam (Domeh l'Dash)** | ✗ **No issue!** Dash requires something *omed l'mashkin* — something with liquid-potential like fruit, or even snow/ice. **Salt is not omed l'mashkeh** — there's no resemblance to Dash |

The **Mishna Berura** writes this explicitly: according to the Rambam, salt and borit (soap) and other things not designated for liquid would be **permitted l'chatchila**.

### The Shulchan Aruch's Dual Position

Interesting observation: the Shulchan Aruch:

1. Placed these halachot in the Dash chapter → holds like **Rambam**
2. But ALSO forbids rubbing salt → that's only explicable like **Rashi**

**Conclusion: the Shulchan Aruch incorporates both reasonings (Rambam AND Rashi) — but certainly not the Ba'al HaTerumah.**

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## The Big Application — Soap on Shabbat (Bar of Soap)

### The Rema's Ruling (Siman 326:10)

> *It is forbidden to wash one's hands with* **ואסור לרחוץ ידיו במלח, וכל שכן בבורית שקורין סאבו"ן, דהוי נולד** *.salt, and all the more so with borit called "sabon" (soap) — for it is nolad*

Just as you can't transform ice → liquid or salt → liquid, **you cannot rub a bar of soap into liquid** on Shabbat. This is how the **Ben Ish Chai** and many Sefardi poskim rule — forbidden.

The Ben Ish Chai explicitly rejects the lenient view: even though while washing, the soap mixes with water droplets already on your hands (and we've learned that transformation INTO existing liquid is permitted) — he still forbids, and says this is the minhag.

### The Lenient View — Pachad Yitzchak & Ginat Veradim

The **Pachad Yitzchak** distinguishes:

> **אבל הבורית מצד עצמו לא יהפך למים, אלא על ידי המים עולה קצף על ידיו, ואין דמיון לבורית עם השלג והברד**

- Snow/ice/salt → **directly transform into liquid water**
- Soap → does NOT become water. It becomes **ketzef — FOAM** — via the water

- Foam is not a liquid → no comparison to snow and ice → **no prohibition**

### The Second Issue Everyone Asks About — Memachek (Smoothing)

Most people think the reason soap is forbidden on Shabbat is **Memachek** (smoothing — like smoothing wax over a barrel opening). But notice: **the Rema never mentions Memachek!** He only raises nolad.

**Chacham Ben Tzion Abba Shaul and Chacham Ovadia derive from this** a very important principle:

**Memareach/Memachek is only forbidden when you are smoothing something in order to make it smooth** — creating a smooth layer you want (like wax sealing a barrel).

Applied to soap:

- **The lather smoothed on your hands?** You have zero interest in it — it's washed off seconds later. Not Memachek at all.
- **The smoothing of the bar itself?** You have no intention for that — it's a **פסיק רישא דלא ניחא ליה** (inevitable but of no benefit to you) on what is at worst a d'Rabbanan — **permitted**.
- *(BUT: if you deliberately rub the bar to make it nice and smooth — which people sometimes do — that is forbidden according to everyone.)*

### The Final Ruling on Soap

| Issue | Analysis |
|---|---|
| **Nolad / transforming solid → liquid** | It becomes foam, not liquid → machloket on a d'Rabbanan → safek d'Rabbanan l'kula |
| **Memachek** | No interest in the smoothness → psik reisha d'lo nicha lei on a d'Rabbanan → permitted |

**Chacham Ovadia:** Mikar hadin, **one may use a bar of soap on Shabbat** — but **ba'al nefesh yachmir** (a scrupulous person should be stringent).

**Practical guidance:**

- If you see people using bar soap on Shabbat — they have what to rely on; no need to correct them
- If you have **liquid soap** available — use it and avoid the whole question

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## Seif 13 — Walking on Snow

**דורס שלג ברגליו ואינו חושש** *.One may tread on snow with his feet and need not be concerned*

### The Halacha

You may walk on snow on Shabbat (to shul, to a friend) — even though your steps crush it.

### Two Reasons in the Acharonim

| Posek | Reason |
|---|---|
| **Vilna Gaon** | **אינו מתכוון** — you have no intention to crush |
| **Taz (Rabbi David Segal)** | **אי אפשר ליזהר** — it's impossible to avoid; there's no alternative (you can't stay trapped at home all Shabbat) |

### Nafka Mina 1 — Half the Pavement Is Clear

Part of the pavement has snow, part is clear:

- **Taz**: You must walk on the clear side — the whole heter is that there's no alternative
- **Vilna Gaon**: Walk wherever is easiest — you're not intending to crush either way
- **Ben Ish Chai rules strictly (like the Taz)**: if there's an alternative route, take it

### Nafka Mina 2 — Enjoying the Crunch

The road is fully snowed; you must walk through it. But you *enjoy* crunching snow (we all know that feeling — wellies on, stomping the snow) and deliberately walk harder to crush it:

- **Taz**: No problem — there's no alternative route anyway
- **Vilna Gaon**: Problem — you're now **mitkaven** (intending) to crush

### Agreed by Both

**Going out to jump on snow in order to crush it** (teenagers/adults for fun) — forbidden according to both reasons: you're either mitkaven (Gra) or have an alternative (Taz — you don't need to be doing this at all).

*(Rabbi Kada: I wouldn't stop young children doing this — no need for chinuch on something like this.)*

### Walking on Ice

Same status as snow — permitted where needed. (Though probably inadvisable for safety reasons!)

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## Seif 14 — Urinating in Snow

*The Maharam of Rothenburg permits urinating* **מהר"ם מרוטנבורג מתיר להטיל מי רגלים בשלג, והרא"ש נזהר** *.in snow; the Rosh was careful (not to)*

### A Teacher-Student Machloket

The Rosh (Rabbeinu Asher) was the **student** of the Maharam MiRotenburg. (Historical note: the Maharam spent years imprisoned; the Rosh fled the German persecutions to Toledo.)

### The Positions

- **Maharam**: Permitted — same logic as walking on snow (no intention to crush / no alternative)
- **Rosh**: Be careful not to — here you're **directly** causing the solid to change to liquid (more like crushing an ice cube in liquid than like incidentally stepping on snow)

### The Halacha

- **If there's any need** — one may be lenient (it's d'Rabbanan, plus kavod haberiyot)
- If there's truly nowhere else to go — everyone agrees it's permitted

- Only one doing so **in order to** melt the snow would have a problem (an unusual case)

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## Seif 15 — A Towel Over the Water Bowl (Sechita of MELABEN)

## Introduction — The Two Sechitot

This is the key conceptual distinction for Part 3 of the siman. **There are two melachot of squeezing, and your intention determines which one applies:**

| Melacha | What You Want | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **Dash (Mefarek)** | You want **the liquid being squeezed out** | Squeezing grapes for juice, olives for oil |
| **Melaben (laundering)** | You want **the garment** — squeezing to *get rid of* the liquid | Wringing out a soaked cloth |

### Melaben Has Three Torah-Level Components

soaking the garment — **(Sheriyah) שריה**

scrubbing/rubbing it — **(Shifshuf) שפשוף**

wringing it out (an essential part of laundering — removing the dirty water) — **(Sechita) סחיטה**

Both melachot are called "sechita" — which is confusing. Squeezing to USE the liquid = Dash. Squeezing to REMOVE the liquid from the item you want = Melaben. **This distinction recurs throughout Hilchot Shabbat.**

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## The Halacha of Seif 15

**אסור לפרוס סודר על פי החבית וליתן על גביו כלי ששואבים בו, שמא יבוא לידי סחיטה. אבל בגד העשוי לפרוס עליו — מותר, שאינו חושש עליו לסוחטו**

### The Case

Many people keep a netilat yadayim set by their bed (bowl + cup of water — so as not to walk daled amot in the morning without washing). The Ben Ish Chai and other poskim also note you shouldn't leave water uncovered (mayim megulim) — so people cover the cup with a towel.

### The Ruling

- **A regular cloth/towel/garment** spread over a water vessel → **FORBIDDEN** — out of concern it will dip into the water and you'll come to **squeeze it out** (sechita of **Melaben** — you want the towel dry, not the liquid)
- **A cloth designated for this use** (your regular netilat yadayim hand towel) → **PERMITTED** — since its nature is to be used with water and be wet, you won't care to squeeze it

### Practical

- Your regular hand towel from the netilat yadayim set → fine to use as a cover on Shabbat
- Friday night and your hand towels are in the wash, so you grab a random shirt or fresh towel from the closet → **forbidden** to use as the cover

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## Seif 16 — Wedging Wet Cotton into a Jug Opening (Sechita of DASH)

**אסור להדק מוכין בפי פך שיש בו משקין, משום סחיטה** *(It is forbidden to wedge soft material (cotton/wadding) into the mouth of a flask containing liquid, because of sechita.*

### The Case

A jug stoppered with soft material (cotton wadding). The wadding is **wet** (it's been sitting in the jug opening). Pressing it back in = **psik reisha** — you will inevitably squeeze liquid out of it **into the jug**.

### Which Sechita Is This?

**DASH** — because the squeezed drops go INTO the jug, adding to your liquid. It's **nicha lei** (beneficial to you) — even a few drops add to your wine/liquid. You're extracting liquid that you keep.

*(Note the confusion: Seif 15's sechita was Melaben; Seif 16's sechita is Dash. Same word, different melachot.)*

### Even Designated Material

Unlike Seif 15 (where a designated cloth was fine), here even designated wadding is a problem — because the issue isn't "you might come to squeeze" (a concern); it's that wedging it **inevitably squeezes** liquid into the jug right now.

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## Seif 17 — Sponges

**ספוג — אין מקנחין בו אלא אם כן יש בו בית אחיזה, גזרה שמא יסחוט** *(A sponge — one may not wipe with it ...unless it has a handle*

### Correction on the Language

The Shulchan Aruch says "gezera shema yischot" but the Gemara's reasoning is **mishum sechita** — it's not a *gezera* (precaution), it's **psik reisha**: holding a wet handle-less sponge and wiping a table **inevitably** squeezes liquid out.

### Which Sechita?

**DASH** — as you wipe, you squeeze liquid out of the sponge and **use that liquid to clean** the surface. You want the extracted liquid → Dash.

### The Halacha

| Sponge | Status |
|---|---|
| Wet sponge, **no handle** | **Forbidden** — psik reisha of squeezing |
| Wet sponge **with a handle** (בית אחיזה) | **Permitted** — no longer inevitable; you use the surface moisture only (still be careful not to squeeze) |

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## Beginning Seif 18 — The Flax Stopper & Psik Reisha D'Lo Nicha Lei

This is the major final seif of the Dash/Melaben section. Tonight we lay the groundwork; we'll finish next shiur.

## Introduction Point 1 — Is There Libun (Laundering) with Liquids Other Than Water?

*(Based on the sugya in Ketubot daf 5-6 and the famous Tosafot there.)*

**The Question:** Melaben means squeezing out to clean. Does it apply when the absorbed liquid is NOT water — e.g., a towel drenched in **red wine** or **Coca-Cola**?

| Opinion | Ruling | Logic |
|---|---|---|
| **Rambam** (and others) | **YES — יש ליבון בשאר משקין** — squeezing out wine IS Melaben (d'Oraita) | Even though the stain and smell remain, you've certainly improved the garment |
| **Rabbeinu Tam** (and many Rishonim) | **NO — אין ליבון בשאר משקין** | Laundering means *cleaning*. Squeeze out water → garment is clean. Squeeze out wine → still dirty. That's not laundering |

**Key for the psak: the Shulchan Aruch rules NOT like the Rambam — there is NO libun with other liquids.** (Squeezing wine out of a cloth is not Melaben.)

## Introduction Point 2 — Dash V'Holech L'Ibud (Squeezing Where the Liquid Goes to Waste)

**Setup:** Clearly, squeezing an expensive wine OUT of a towel INTO a cup (to save the wine) = **Dash from the Torah** — you want the extracted liquid.

**The Question:** What if I squeeze the wine out of the towel and it **goes to waste** (down the drain)? No Melaben issue (per the Shulchan Aruch's ruling — wine isn't libun). Is the squeezing itself a Dash problem?

| Opinion | Ruling | Logic |
|---|---|---|
| **Rabbeinu Tam** | **Assur d'Rabbanan** | It's Dash performed as a מלאכה שאינה צריכה לגופה (extraction not for the sake of using the extract) |
| **Other Rishonim** | **Muttar** | Squeezing-to-waste simply ISN'T Dash. The essence of Dash-sechita is *wanting what comes out*. Squeezing to discard falls under the *category* of Melaben — and if the liquid has no libun (wine), it's permitted entirely |

## The Seif Itself (Begun)

**חבית שפקקה בפקק של פשתן שמוצין בה היין, יש מי שמתיר (להסירו) אף על פי שאי אפשר שלא יסחוט**

*A barrel stoppered with a flax stopper through which wine is drawn — there is one who permits (removing/reinserting it) even though it is impossible not to squeeze.*

*(Textual note: the word להסירו was added by the Mishna Berura's explanation and copied into modern editions — it's not in the original Shulchan Aruch text. The meaning: to remove and reinsert the stopper.)*

### The Famous Opinion — The Ba'al HaAruch

This is the celebrated position of the **Aruch** (one of the early Rishonim):

A psik reisha (inevitable consequence) in which you have **no interest** — **פסיק רישא דלא ניחא ליה — מותר** is **PERMITTED**, even where the melacha would be d'Oraita.

### Defining "Lo Nicha Lei" Precisely

**Critical clarification:** *Lo nicha lei* does NOT mean "it's bad for me." It means **"I have no interest / no benefit in it."**

Proof from Tosafot: the Gemara's case of watering **בארעא דחבריה** (a friend's field) — the water benefits the friend's land, nothing bad happens — yet it's still called *psik reisha d'lo nicha lei* because **I** have no interest in it. Indifference qualifies as *lo nicha lei*.

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## To Be Continued Next Shiur

- Completing Seif 18: how the machloket about psik reisha d'lo nicha lei plays out
- The Mishna Berura's treatment and halacha l'ma'aseh applications
- Then: **Melechet Tzovei'a** (dyeing) — the final two seifim of the siman

*(Note: no shiur next Thursday; regular shiurim otherwise — Monday HaMaspik, Tuesday Moreh.)*

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## Summary Table of Tonight's Halachot

| Seif | Topic | Bottom Line |
|---|---|---|
| **10** | Breaking ice to reach water | **Permitted** — intention is access, not liquid creation |
| **11** | Washing hands with snow/ice water | Avoid; if you do — don't rub hands together |
| — | Freezing water into ice cubes | **Permitted for everyone** (for that Shabbat's use) |
| **12** | Rubbing salt | Forbidden (Shulchan Aruch incorporates Rashi's reason) |
| — | **Bar of soap** | Mikar hadin **permitted** (foam ≠ liquid; no Memachek interest); ba'al nefesh yachmir; liquid soap avoids the question |
| **13** | Walking on snow | **Permitted**; don't deliberately stomp to crush; Ben Ish Chai: take a clear path if one exists |
| **14** | Urinating in snow | Maharam permits, Rosh careful; lenient if any need |
| **15** | Towel over water bowl | Designated towel — permitted; random garment — forbidden (Melaben concern) |
| **16** | Wet cotton wedged in jug | Forbidden — psik reisha of Dash (drops squeezed into your liquid) |
| **17** | Wet sponge | Forbidden without a handle; permitted with one |
| **18** | Flax stopper (begun) | The Aruch: psik reisha d'lo nicha lei is permitted — to be continued |

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*B'Ezrat Hashem*

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